

Jeremiah 22 - 24

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight Yahweh walks down the hill to the palace and audits the throne - and then, having found every occupant of it wanting, He promises a King who will not be.

A cedar-panelled house built with wages never paid.

A signet ring pulled off the right hand that wore it.

A righteous Branch raised up to David, whose name is Yahweh Our Righteousness.

Two baskets of figs on the temple steps - one good, one so rotten no one would touch it - and the shock of finding out which basket is which.

Jeremiah 22 works through three of Josiah's descendants by name and asks the question that undoes them all: your father did justice and it was well with him - wasn't that what it means to know me?

Jeremiah 23 turns on the shepherds who scattered the flock and the prophets who ran without being sent, and in the middle of that indictment sets the clearest messianic promise in the book so far.

Jeremiah 24 upends every assumption about who is blessed, by declaring that the ones already carried off to Babylon are the good figs.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 22 - Cedar Palaces and the Signet Plucked Off

Key Notes

- Jeremiah is sent down to the palace itself - not to summon the king to the temple, but to stand in his house and address him where he governs (Jeremiah 22:1-2).
- The requirement laid on the throne is entirely ethical and entirely concrete: justice and righteousness, the robbed delivered, no violence to the foreigner, the fatherless, or the widow, no innocent blood (Jeremiah 22:3).
- The Davidic promise is presented as conditional in practice. Do this, and kings keep riding through these gates; refuse, and Yahweh swears by Himself that the house becomes a ruin (Jeremiah 22:4-5).
- The palace is addressed as a forest - Gilead, the head of Lebanon - because it was panelled in imported cedar. Yahweh promises woodsmen with axes (Jeremiah 22:6-7).
- The nations will ask why, and the answer given is not military but covenantal: they abandoned the covenant of Yahweh their God and served other gods (Jeremiah 22:8-9).
- Shallum - the king 2 Kings calls Jehoahaz - reigned three months and died in Egypt. Weep for the exiled living rather than the buried dead (Jeremiah 22:10-12).
- The woe against Jehoiakim is about labor practices: a wide house with spacious rooms and painted cedar, built by neighbors who were never paid their wages (Jeremiah 22:13-14).
- Then the sentence that indicts every religious generation: Josiah did justice and judged the cause of the poor and needy - "wasn't this to know me?" Knowing Yahweh is defined as behavior toward the vulnerable (Jeremiah 22:15-16).
- Jehoiakim will be buried with the burial of a donkey, dragged out beyond the gates - no lament, no "Ah, my brother," no royal mourning at all (Jeremiah 22:18-19).
- Coniah - Jehoiachin - is called the signet on Yahweh's right hand, the most intimate image of authority available, and is then plucked off it and thrown into a land he was not born in (Jeremiah 22:24-27).
- The chapter ends with a triple cry, "O earth, earth, earth," and a verdict recording Coniah as childless: no descendant of his will prosper on David's throne (Jeremiah 22:28-30).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Justice for the Foreigner, Fatherless, and Widow	Jeremiah 22:3 • Exodus 22:21-22 • Deuteronomy 24:17
Yahweh Swearing by Himself	Jeremiah 22:5 • Amos 6:8 • Hebrews 6:13
The Nations Asking Why	Jeremiah 22:8-9 • 1 Kings 9:8-9 • 2 Chronicles 7:21-22
Shallum, the King Who Died in Egypt	Jeremiah 22:11-12 • 2 Kings 23:31-34 • 2 Chronicles 36:1-4

Topic	References
Wages Withheld From a Neighbor	Jeremiah 22:13 • Leviticus 19:13 • Deuteronomy 24:14-15
Knowing Yahweh Defined as Doing Justice	Jeremiah 22:16 • Micah 6:6-8 • Hosea 6:6
The Burial of a Donkey	Jeremiah 22:19 • 2 Kings 24:6 • Jeremiah 36:30
The Signet Plucked From the Hand	Jeremiah 22:24 • Haggai 2:23 • Song of Solomon 8:6

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Justice, Mercy, and Faith - the Weightier Matters	Jeremiah 22:3 • Matthew 23:23 • James 1:27
The Cry of the Unpaid Laborer	Jeremiah 22:13 • James 5:4 • Malachi 3:5
Done to the Least of These	Jeremiah 22:16 • Matthew 25:40 • 1 John 3:17
The Curse on Jeconiah and the Two Genealogies	Jeremiah 22:30 • Matthew 1:11-12 • Luke 3:23-31
A Signet Restored in Zerubbabel's Line	Jeremiah 22:24 • Haggai 2:23 • Zechariah 4:6-7
The King Whose Throne Is Never Vacated	Jeremiah 22:30 • Luke 1:32-33 • Hebrews 1:8

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 22 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the oracles against Shallum, Jehoiakim, and Coniah, and the cedar-palace woe
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 22](#) - Torah-grounded treatment of the justice requirements laid on the Davidic throne
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 22](#) - careful handling of the Jeconiah verdict and how the messianic line passes around it

Jeremiah 22 - Opening Intro

This chapter is a royal audit, and the standard it audits by is not orthodoxy. Yahweh does not ask the kings of Judah about their theology, their temple attendance, or their liturgical reforms. He asks what happened to the widow, the orphan, the foreigner, and the man whose wages were withheld.

Verse 16 is the hinge, and it is worth reading twice. Yahweh describes Josiah - ate and drank, did justice and righteousness, judged the cause of the poor and needy - and then asks, "Wasn't this to know me?" Not "this proved he knew me." This was knowing Him. The doing and the knowing are the same act.

Set against that, Jehoiakim's crime is almost mundane. He wanted a nicer house. Spacious rooms, cut windows, cedar ceiling, painted vermilion - and he built it with unpaid labor. There is no idol mentioned in his woe. Just a construction project and a payroll he never met.

Then comes Coniah, and the image Yahweh uses is startling in its intimacy. A signet ring is how an ancient king signed his name; it never left his hand. Yahweh says: even if he were the signet on my right hand, I would pull him off. And He does.

One thread to hold as you read, because it becomes important next chapter: verse 30 records Coniah as childless and says no offspring of his will prosper on David's throne. That looks like the end of the promise. Matthew's genealogy runs Messiah's legal line straight through Jeconiah, while Luke's traces a different branch of David's house entirely - which is one reason many readers see the two genealogies as answering exactly this verse.

Before we read, let the standard land where it lands. If knowing God is measured by how the powerless in our reach are treated, then most of us have been measuring ourselves with the wrong instrument.

Jeremiah 22:1-30 (WEB)

1 Yahweh said, "Go down to the house of the king of Judah, and speak this word, there:

2 'Hear Yahweh's word, king of Judah, who sits on David's throne, you, your servants, and your people who enter in by these gates.

3 Yahweh says: "Execute justice and righteousness, and deliver him who is robbed out of the hand of the oppressor. Do no wrong. Do no violence to the foreigner, the fatherless, or the widow. Don't shed innocent blood in this place.^{1,2}

4 For if you do this thing indeed, then kings sitting on David's throne will enter in by the gates of this house, riding in chariots and on horses, he, his servants, and his people.

5 But if you will not hear these words, I swear by myself," says Yahweh, "that this house will become a desolation."'''

6 For Yahweh says concerning the house of the king of Judah: "You are Gilead to me, the head of Lebanon. Yet surely I will make you a wilderness, cities which are not inhabited.

7 I will prepare destroyers against you, everyone with his weapons, and they will cut down your choice cedars, and cast them into the fire.

8 "Many nations will pass by this city, and they will each ask his neighbor, 'Why has Yahweh done this to this great city?'

¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Exodus 22:21-22](#) • [Deuteronomy 24:17](#) - the Torah's standing protections for the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow

² **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 23:23](#) • [James 1:27](#) - the weightier matters of the law, and religion measured by care for orphans and widows

9 Then they will answer, 'Because they abandoned the covenant of Yahweh their God, worshiped other gods, and served them.'"³

10 Don't weep for the dead. Don't bemoan him; but weep bitterly for him who goes away, for he will return no more, and not see his native country.

11 For Yahweh says touching Shallum the son of Josiah, king of Judah, who reigned instead of Josiah his father, and who went out of this place: "He won't return there any more."⁴

12 But in the place where they have led him captive, there will he die. He will see this land no more."

13 "Woe to him who builds his house by unrighteousness, and his rooms by injustice; who uses his neighbor's service without wages, and doesn't give him his hire;"^{5,6}

14 who says, 'I will build myself a wide house and spacious rooms,' and cuts out windows for himself; with a cedar ceiling, and painted with red.

15 "Should you reign, because you strive to excel in cedar? Didn't your father eat and drink, and do justice and righteousness? Then it was well with him.

16 He judged the cause of the poor and needy; so it was well, then. Wasn't this to know me?" says Yahweh."^{7,8}

17 But your eyes and your heart are only for your covetousness, for shedding innocent blood, for oppression, and for doing violence."

18 Therefore Yahweh says concerning Jehoiakim the son of Josiah, king of Judah: "They won't lament for him, saying, 'Ah my brother!' or, 'Ah sister!' They won't lament for him, saying 'Ah lord!' or, 'Ah his glory!'

19 He will be buried with the burial of a donkey, drawn and cast out beyond the gates of Jerusalem."⁹

20 "Go up to Lebanon, and cry. Lift up your voice in Bashan, and cry from Abarim; for all your lovers have been destroyed.

³ **Cross-Reference:** [1 Kings 9:8-9](#) • [2 Chronicles 7:21-22](#) - the answer given to the nations was written into the temple dedication itself

⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [2 Kings 23:31-34](#) • [2 Chronicles 36:1-4](#) - Shallum is Jehoahaz - three months on the throne, then deposed and taken to Egypt

⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 19:13](#) • [Deuteronomy 24:14-15](#) - wages not to be held back overnight, because the poor man depends on them that day

⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [James 5:4](#) • [Malachi 3:5](#) - the cry of the harvesters reaching the ears of the Lord of Armies

⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Micah 6:6-8](#) • [Hosea 6:6](#) - what Yahweh actually requires - justice, kindness, humility, and mercy over sacrifice

⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 25:40](#) • [1 John 3:17](#) - done to the least of these, and love proven by what we do with what we have

⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [2 Kings 24:6](#) • [Jeremiah 36:30](#) - Jehoiakim's end, recorded with conspicuous silence about any royal burial

21 I spoke to you in your prosperity; but you said, 'I will not listen.' This has been your way from your youth, that you didn't obey my voice.

22 The wind will feed all your shepherds, and your lovers will go into captivity. Surely then you will be ashamed and confounded for all your wickedness.

23 Inhabitant of Lebanon, who makes your nest in the cedars, how greatly to be pitied you will be when pangs come on you, the pain as of a woman in travail!

24 "As I live," says Yahweh, "though Coniah the son of Jehoiakim king of Judah were the signet on my right hand, yet would I pluck you from there."¹⁰

25 I would give you into the hand of those who seek your life, and into the hand of them of whom you are afraid, even into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, and into the hand of the Chaldeans.

26 I will cast you out with your mother who bore you into another country, where you were not born; and there you will die.

27 But to the land to which their soul longs to return, there they will not return."

28 Is this man Coniah a despised broken vessel? Is he a vessel in which no one delights? Why are they cast out, he and his offspring, and cast into a land which they don't know?

29 O earth, earth, earth, hear Yahweh's word!

30 Yahweh says, "Record this man as childless, a man who will not prosper in his days; for no more will a man of his offspring prosper, sitting on David's throne, and ruling in Judah."^{11,12}

¹⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Haggai 2:23](#) • [Song of Solomon 8:6](#) - the signet as the seal of a man's own authority, worn where it never leaves him

¹¹ **Cross-Reference:** [1 Chronicles 3:17-18](#) • [2 Kings 25:27-30](#) - Jeconiah's recorded offspring, and the strange kindness shown him at the end of his life

¹² **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 1:11-12](#) • [Luke 3:23-31](#) - the legal line running through Jeconiah and a separate Davidic line traced by Luke

CHAPTER 23 - The Righteous Branch and the Prophets Who Ran Unsent

Key Notes

- The woe falls on the shepherds - the same kings just audited - for scattering the flock and failing to visit them. Yahweh's counter-threat is exact: "I will visit on you" (Jeremiah 23:1-2).
- Yahweh then takes the shepherd's job Himself: "I will gather the remnant of my flock out of all the countries where I have driven them," and will set up shepherds who actually feed (Jeremiah 23:3-4).
- The promise arrives in the language of horticulture, not politics: a righteous Branch raised up to David, who will reign and deal wisely and execute justice - the very thing the last four kings would not do (Jeremiah 23:5).
- His name is the whole gospel in four words: "Yahweh our righteousness." Not a king who enforces righteousness on others, but one who *is* righteousness for the people He rules (Jeremiah 23:6).
- As in chapter 16, the coming deliverance will retire the exodus as Israel's defining oath - the new testimony will be the gathering out of the north country (Jeremiah 23:7-8).
- Jeremiah's own reaction to the oracles against the prophets is physical: a broken heart, shaking bones, the disorientation of a drunk man - "because of Yahweh, and because of his holy words" (Jeremiah 23:9).
- The corruption has reached the sanctuary: "both prophet and priest are profane. Yes, in my house I have found their wickedness" (Jeremiah 23:10-11).
- The false prophets' message is diagnosed precisely - they promise peace to those who despise Yahweh and safety to those walking in the stubbornness of their own hearts (Jeremiah 23:16-17).
- The test is stated as a question about proximity: who has stood in the council of Yahweh? Had they stood there, they would have turned the people from evil instead of soothing them (Jeremiah 23:18-22).
- "Am I a God at hand, and not a God afar off?" answers the theology behind false prophecy - a local, manageable deity who fills a shrine rather than heaven and earth (Jeremiah 23:23-24).
- The dream-peddlers are contrasted with the faithful: "What is the straw to the wheat?" And the word itself is described as fire and as a hammer that breaks rock (Jeremiah 23:25-29).
- The chapter ends by banning a phrase. They had turned "the burden of Yahweh" into a joke, so Yahweh takes the expression away from them entirely (Jeremiah 23:33-40).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Woe to the Shepherds Who Scatter	Jeremiah 23:1-2 • Ezekiel 34:2-4 • Zechariah 11:16-17
The Remnant Gathered and Multiplied	Jeremiah 23:3 • Micah 2:12 • Isaiah 11:11-12

Topic	References
A Righteous Branch Raised to David	Jeremiah 23:5 • Isaiah 11:1 • Zechariah 3:8
A Second Exodus Out of the North	Jeremiah 23:7-8 • Jeremiah 16:14-15 • Isaiah 43:5-6
Prophet and Priest Profane in His House	Jeremiah 23:11 • Jeremiah 6:13 • Zephaniah 3:4
Peace Promised to Those Who Despise Him	Jeremiah 23:17 • Jeremiah 6:14 • Micah 3:11
Standing in the Council of Yahweh	Jeremiah 23:18 • Amos 3:7 • 1 Kings 22:19-23
No Hiding Place - He Fills Heaven and Earth	Jeremiah 23:24 • Psalm 139:7-10 • 1 Kings 8:27

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
One Shepherd Over One Flock	Jeremiah 23:4 • Ezekiel 34:23 • John 10:14-16
The Branch Who Reigns and Deals Wisely	Jeremiah 23:5 • Luke 1:32-33 • Revelation 22:16
Yahweh Our Righteousness	Jeremiah 23:6 • 1 Corinthians 1:30 • 2 Corinthians 5:21
Justice and Righteousness Executed in the Land	Jeremiah 23:5 • Isaiah 9:6-7 • Psalm 72:1-2
Servants Told the Master's Business	Jeremiah 23:18 • John 15:15 • 1 Corinthians 2:16
Straw and Wheat Finally Separated	Jeremiah 23:28 • Matthew 3:12 • Psalm 1:4
The Word as Fire and Hammer	Jeremiah 23:29 • Hebrews 4:12 • Acts 2:37

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 23 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the Righteous Branch oracle and a full treatment of the marks of a false prophet
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 23](#) - "Yahweh our righteousness" read in its covenant and kingdom context
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 23](#) - exposition of the Branch prophecy and the council-of-Yahweh test in verse 18

Jeremiah 23 - Opening Intro

Notice how this chapter is built. Yahweh dismantles the shepherds, and then - before He says a word about replacements - He says what He Himself will do. "I will gather." "I will bring them again." "I will set up shepherds." The failure of leadership is real, and it is not the last word about the flock.

Then comes verse 5, and the metaphor is deliberate. Judah's royal house had just been described as a cedar forest marked for the axe. Now Yahweh promises a tsemach - a shoot, a sprout, the green thing that comes up out of a stump after the tree has been cut down. The dynasty is going to be felled. Something is going to grow anyway.

And His name stops you: Yahweh Tsidkenu, Yahweh Our Righteousness. Every king in chapter 22 was measured by whether he *did* righteousness. This One is called righteousness - not the enforcer of a standard but the supply of it for the people He governs. Chapter 22 asks what a righteous king owes his people; chapter 23 answers that the King will be their righteousness.

The rest of the chapter is about how to tell a true word from a comfortable one, and Yahweh's test in verse 18 is not about accuracy or eloquence. It is about location. Has this man stood in my council? Because if he had, he would have come back saying something that turned people from evil, not something that let them stay where they were.

There is a Hebrew wordplay in the closing section that the English cannot carry. The word massa means both "oracle" and "burden." The people had begun sneering, "What's the burden of Yahweh today?" - and Yahweh answers by taking the word off their tongues: you may not use that phrase anymore.

Before we read, hold verse 29 next to verse 17. One kind of preaching tells people what they wish were true. The other is fire and a hammer that breaks rock. Both feel like ministry from the inside. Only one of them has been anywhere near the council of Yahweh.

Jeremiah 23:1-40 (WEB)

1 "Woe to the shepherds who destroy and scatter the sheep of my pasture!" says Yahweh.¹³

2 Therefore Yahweh, the God of Israel, says against the shepherds who feed my people: "You have scattered my flock, driven them away, and have not visited them. Behold, I will visit on you the evil of your doings," says Yahweh.

3 "I will gather the remnant of my flock out of all the countries where I have driven them, and will bring them again to their folds; and they will be fruitful and multiply.

4 I will set up shepherds over them, who will feed them. They will no longer be afraid or dismayed, neither will any be lacking," says Yahweh.¹⁴

5 "Behold, the days come," says Yahweh, "that I will raise to David a righteous Branch, and he will reign as king and deal wisely, and will execute justice and righteousness in the land."^{15,16}

¹³ Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 34:2-4](#) • [Zechariah 11:16-17](#) - shepherds who fed themselves and the worthless shepherd who does not care for the flock

¹⁴ Messianic Connection: [Ezekiel 34:23](#) • [John 10:14-16](#) - one shepherd raised up over them, and one flock gathered under one Shepherd

¹⁵ Cross-Reference: [Isaiah 11:1](#) • [Zechariah 3:8](#) - the shoot out of the stump of Jesse, and My servant the Branch

¹⁶ Messianic Connection: [Luke 1:32-33](#) • [Revelation 22:16](#) - the throne of David given Him forever, the root and offspring of David

6 In his days Judah will be saved, and Israel will dwell safely. This is his name by which he will be called: Yahweh our righteousness.¹⁷

7 “Therefore behold, the days come,” says Yahweh, “that they will no more say, ‘As Yahweh lives, who brought up the children of Israel out of the land of Egypt;’

8 but, ‘As Yahweh lives, who brought up and who led the offspring of the house of Israel out of the north country, and from all the countries where I had driven them.’ Then they will dwell in their own land.”¹⁸

9 Concerning the prophets: My heart within me is broken. All my bones shake. I am like a drunken man, and like a man whom wine has overcome, because of Yahweh, and because of his holy words.

10 For the land is full of adulterers; for because of the curse the land mourns. The pastures of the wilderness have dried up. Their course is evil, and their might is not right;

11 for both prophet and priest are profane. Yes, in my house I have found their wickedness,” says Yahweh.

12 Therefore their way will be to them as slippery places in the darkness. They will be driven on, and fall therein; for I will bring evil on them, even the year of their visitation,” says Yahweh.

13 “I have seen folly in the prophets of Samaria. They prophesied by Baal, and caused my people Israel to err.

14 In the prophets of Jerusalem I have also seen a horrible thing: they commit adultery and walk in lies. They strengthen the hands of evildoers, so that no one returns from his wickedness. They have all become to me as Sodom, and its inhabitants as Gomorrah.”

15 Therefore Yahweh of Armies says concerning the prophets: “Behold, I will feed them with wormwood, and make them drink the water of gall; for from the prophets of Jerusalem ungodliness has gone out into all the land.”

16 Yahweh of Armies says, “Don’t listen to the words of the prophets who prophesy to you. They teach you vanity. They speak a vision of their own heart, and not out of the mouth of Yahweh.

17 They say continually to those who despise me, ‘Yahweh has said, “You will have peace;”’ and to everyone who walks in the stubbornness of his own heart they say, ‘No evil will come on you.’¹⁹

¹⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [1 Corinthians 1:30](#) • [2 Corinthians 5:21](#) - Messiah made unto us righteousness - we become the righteousness of God in Him

¹⁸ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 16:14-15](#) • [Isaiah 43:5-6](#) - the gathering from the north that will replace the exodus as Israel’s defining oath

¹⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 6:14](#) • [Micah 3:11](#) - peace announced where there is no peace, by men who lean on Yahweh while selling comfort

18 For who has stood in the council of Yahweh, that he should perceive and hear his word? Who has listened to my word, and heard it?^{20,21}

19 Behold, Yahweh's storm, his wrath, has gone out. Yes, a whirling storm: It will burst on the head of the wicked.

20 Yahweh's anger will not return until he has executed, and until he has performed the intents of his heart. In the latter days, you will understand it perfectly.

21 I didn't send these prophets, yet they ran. I didn't speak to them, yet they prophesied.

22 But if they had stood in my council, then they would have caused my people to hear my words, and would have turned them from their evil way, and from the evil of their doings.

23 "Am I a God at hand," says Yahweh, "and not a God afar off?"

24 Can anyone hide himself in secret places so that I can't see him?" says Yahweh. "Don't I fill heaven and earth?" says Yahweh.²²

25 "I have heard what the prophets have said, who prophesy lies in my name, saying, 'I had a dream! I had a dream!'

26 How long will this be in the heart of the prophets who prophesy lies, even the prophets of the deceit of their own heart?

27 They intend to cause my people to forget my name by their dreams which they each tell his neighbor, as their fathers forgot my name because of Baal.

28 The prophet who has a dream, let him tell a dream; and he who has my word, let him speak my word faithfully. What is the straw to the wheat?" says Yahweh.²³

29 "Isn't my word like fire?" says Yahweh; "and like a hammer that breaks the rock in pieces?"²⁴

30 "Therefore behold, I am against the prophets," says Yahweh, "who each steal my words from his neighbor.

31 Behold, I am against the prophets," says Yahweh, "who use their tongues, and say, 'He says.'

²⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Amos 3:7](#) • [1 Kings 22:19-23](#) - Yahweh revealing His secret to His servants, and a real glimpse of the heavenly council

²¹ **Messianic Connection:** [John 15:15](#) • [1 Corinthians 2:16](#) - no longer servants but friends, told everything the Father made known - and given His mind

²² **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 139:7-10](#) • [1 Kings 8:27](#) - nowhere to flee from His presence, and heaven itself unable to contain Him

²³ **Cross-Reference:** [Matthew 3:12](#) • [Psalm 1:4](#) - the threshing floor cleared, and chaff driven away by the wind

²⁴ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 4:12](#) • [Acts 2:37](#) - the word living and active, cutting to the heart of those who hear it

32 Behold, I am against those who prophesy lying dreams," says Yahweh, "who tell them, and cause my people to err by their lies, and by their vain boasting; yet I didn't send them or command them. They don't profit this people at all," says Yahweh.

33 "When this people, or the prophet, or a priest, asks you, saying, 'What is the message from Yahweh?' Then you shall tell them, "'What message? I will cast you off," says Yahweh.'

34 As for the prophet, the priest, and the people, who say, 'The message from Yahweh,' I will even punish that man and his household.

35 You will say everyone to his neighbor, and everyone to his brother, 'What has Yahweh answered?' and, 'What has Yahweh said?'

36 You will mention the message from Yahweh no more: for every man's own word has become his message; for you have perverted the words of the living God, of Yahweh of Armies, our God.

37 You will say to the prophet, 'What has Yahweh answered you?' and, 'What has Yahweh spoken?'

38 Although you say, 'The message from Yahweh;' therefore Yahweh says: 'Because you say this word, "The message from Yahweh," and I have sent to you, telling you not to say, "The message from Yahweh;"

39 therefore, behold, I will utterly forget you, and I will cast you off, and the city that I gave to you and to your fathers, away from my presence.

40 I will bring an everlasting reproach on you, and a perpetual shame, which will not be forgotten.'"

CHAPTER 24 - Two Baskets of Figs and a Heart to Know Him

Key Notes

- The vision is dated: after Nebuchadnezzar carried off Jeconiah, the princes, the craftsmen and the smiths. This is the deportation of 597 BC, and Jerusalem is still standing (Jeremiah 24:1).
- Two baskets sit in front of the temple. One holds figs like the first-ripe - the earliest, sweetest harvest. The other holds figs too rotten to eat (Jeremiah 24:2).
- Yahweh asks the prophetic question He asks throughout Scripture - "What do you see, Jeremiah?" - and waits for the man to say it out loud before explaining it (Jeremiah 24:3).
- Then the shock. The good figs are the exiles. The people everyone in Jerusalem regarded as the casualties of divine anger are the ones Yahweh regards "for good" (Jeremiah 24:5).
- "I will set my eyes on them for good" reverses the language of judgment used earlier in the book, where His eyes were on all their ways for evil (Jeremiah 24:6).
- The four verbs of Jeremiah's original call return, and this time only the constructive two are used: "I will build them, and not pull them down. I will plant them, and not pluck them up" (Jeremiah 24:6).
- Verse 7 is the theological center: "I will give them a heart to know me." The knowing is not achieved by the exiles - it is given to them, and the returning follows from the gift (Jeremiah 24:7).
- The covenant formula appears in full - "They will be my people, and I will be their God" - inside a chapter about deportees rather than temple worshipers (Jeremiah 24:7).
- The bad figs are Zedekiah, his princes, the remnant left in Jerusalem, and those who fled to Egypt: everyone still living in the promised land and still congratulating themselves for it (Jeremiah 24:8).
- Their sentence is dispersal without purpose - a reproach, a proverb, a taunt, and a curse in every place they are driven, until they are consumed off the land (Jeremiah 24:9-10).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Deportation of 597	Jeremiah 24:1 • 2 Kings 24:14-16 • Jeremiah 22:24-27
First-Ripe Figs as an Image of Israel	Jeremiah 24:2 • Hosea 9:10 • Micah 7:1
"What Do You See?" - the Prophetic Question	Jeremiah 24:3 • Amos 7:8 • Zechariah 4:2
Exile as the Place of God's Good Purpose	Jeremiah 24:5 • Jeremiah 29:4-7 • Ezekiel 11:16
Built and Planted, Not Pulled Down	Jeremiah 24:6 • Jeremiah 1:10 • Jeremiah 31:28
A Heart Given to Know Him	Jeremiah 24:7 • Deuteronomy 30:6 • Ezekiel 11:19-20
Those Who Fled to Egypt	Jeremiah 24:8 • Jeremiah 44:12-14 • Isaiah 30:1-3
A Proverb and a Byword Among the	Jeremiah 24:9 • Deuteronomy 28:37 • 1 Kings 9:7

Topic	References
Nations	

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Fig Tree Inspected for Fruit	Jeremiah 24:2 • Mark 11:13-14 • Luke 13:6-9
Planted and Never Plucked Up Again	Jeremiah 24:6 • Amos 9:15 • John 15:16
They Shall All Know Me	Jeremiah 24:7 • Jeremiah 31:33 • Hebrews 8:10-11
A New Heart Given, Not Earned	Jeremiah 24:7 • Ezekiel 36:26-27 • Titus 3:5
My People, and I Their God	Jeremiah 24:7 • 2 Corinthians 6:16 • Revelation 21:3
Branches Broken Off and Branches Taken Away	Jeremiah 24:10 • Romans 11:20-23 • John 15:2

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 24 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the two-baskets vision and the reversal of who counts as blessed
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 24](#) - the good figs, the promise of a heart to know Him, and the covenant formula in verse 7
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 24](#) - exposition of why exile was mercy and remaining in the land was judgment

Jeremiah 24 - Opening Intro

Everything about this chapter depends on knowing who was in Jerusalem when it was given.

In 597 BC Nebuchadnezzar took the young king Jeconiah, the nobles, and every skilled craftsman and metalworker in the city, and marched them to Babylon. The people left behind drew the obvious conclusion. Those exiles must have been the wicked ones. We are the ones God spared. The temple is still standing and we are still standing in it.

So Yahweh sets two baskets of figs in front of them, and asks Jeremiah to say what he sees, and then tells him which basket is which. The good figs - the early-ripe ones, the kind you eat first because they are the best of the harvest - are the deportees. The rotten figs are the congregation still attending services in Jerusalem.

That should unsettle anyone who has ever read their own circumstances as a scorecard. Being in the land was not proof of favor. Being in Babylon was not proof of rejection. Yahweh says of the exiles, "I

will set my eyes on them for good” - and He says it while they are seven hundred miles from the temple with nothing left of their religion but a memory.

Then verse 7, which is the quiet mountain in this chapter: “I will give them a heart to know me.” Not I will command them to know me. Not I will wait for them to decide to know me. I will give them the organ with which knowing happens. And notice the order - the heart is given first, and the returning with the whole heart follows from it. Grace is upstream of repentance here, and Jeremiah says so nineteen chapters before he says it again in chapter 31.

Before we read, hold this gently: the losses that looked like judgment may be the very furnace where a heart to know Him is being formed. The people with everything intact were the ones in trouble.

Jeremiah 24:1-10 (WEB)

1 Yahweh showed me, and behold, two baskets of figs were set before Yahweh’s temple, after Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon had carried away captive Jeconiah the son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah, and the princes of Judah, with the craftsmen and smiths, from Jerusalem, and had brought them to Babylon.²⁵

2 One basket had very good figs, like the figs that are first-ripe; and the other basket had very bad figs, which could not be eaten, they were so bad.²⁶⁻²⁷

3 Then Yahweh asked me, “What do you see, Jeremiah?” I said, “Figs. The good figs are very good, and the bad are very bad, so bad that can’t be eaten.”²⁸

4 Yahweh’s word came to me, saying,

5 “Yahweh, the God of Israel says: ‘Like these good figs, so I will regard the captives of Judah, whom I have sent out of this place into the land of the Chaldeans, for good.’²⁹

6 For I will set my eyes on them for good, and I will bring them again to this land. I will build them, and not pull them down. I will plant them, and not pluck them up.^{30,31}

²⁵ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 24:14-16](#) • [Jeremiah 22:24-27](#) - the 597 deportation of Jeconiah, the nobles, the craftsmen and the smiths

²⁶ Cross-Reference: [Hosea 9:10](#) • [Micah 7:1](#) - Israel as first-ripe figs, and the prophet’s grief when no early fruit is left

²⁷ Messianic Connection: [Mark 11:13-14](#) • [Luke 13:6-9](#) - the fig tree inspected for fruit, and the extra season granted before the axe

²⁸ Cross-Reference: [Amos 7:8](#) • [Zechariah 4:2](#) - the same question put to other prophets - what do you see? - before any word is given

²⁹ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 29:4-7](#) • [Ezekiel 11:16](#) - exile as an assignment with a future, and Yahweh Himself a sanctuary in the countries

³⁰ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 1:10](#) • [Jeremiah 31:28](#) - the four verbs of the original call, now with only build and plant in view

³¹ Messianic Connection: [Amos 9:15](#) • [John 15:16](#) - planted in their land no more to be uprooted, and fruit appointed to remain

7 I will give them a heart to know me, that I am Yahweh. They will be my people, and I will be their God; for they will return to me with their whole heart.^{32,33}

8 “‘As the bad figs, which can’t be eaten, they are so bad,’ surely Yahweh says, ‘So I will give up Zedekiah the king of Judah, and his princes, and the remnant of Jerusalem, who remain in this land, and those who dwell in the land of Egypt.’”³⁴

9 I will even give them up to be tossed back and forth among all the kingdoms of the earth for evil; to be a reproach and a proverb, a taunt and a curse, in all places where I will drive them.³⁵

10 I will send the sword, the famine, and the pestilence, among them, until they are consumed from off the land that I gave to them and to their fathers.””³⁶

³² **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 30:6](#) • [Ezekiel 11:19-20](#) - the heart circumcised by Yahweh Himself, and one heart given so that they walk in His statutes

³³ **Messianic Connection:** [Jeremiah 31:33](#) • [Hebrews 8:10-11](#) - the new covenant promise that they shall all know Me, from the least to the greatest

³⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 44:12-14](#) • [Isaiah 30:1-3](#) - the fate of those who took shelter in Egypt instead of accepting the discipline

³⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 28:37](#) • [1 Kings 9:7](#) - becoming an astonishment, a proverb, and a byword among all peoples

³⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [Romans 11:20-23](#) • [John 15:2](#) - branches broken off through unbelief and grafted back through faith - the Vinedresser’s work

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 22-24

- Knowing Yahweh defined as doing justice - the poor and needy as the instrument that measures a heart
- Power audited by how it treats the powerless, with unpaid wages weighed as heavily as idolatry
- The Davidic promise held and threatened at once: kings plucked off like a signet, the line never ended
- A stump felled and a Branch raised - Yahweh growing something out of what He Himself cut down
- Yahweh Our Righteousness: a King who supplies righteousness rather than merely demanding it
- Yahweh taking up the shepherd's work Himself when every appointed shepherd has scattered the flock
- The test of a true word - not eloquence or accuracy, but whether the speaker has stood in His council
- A God who fills heaven and earth against a God kept conveniently local and manageable
- Circumstances read wrongly: exile as mercy, an intact life as judgment, and the baskets reversed
- A heart to know Him given as a gift, with wholehearted return as the fruit of the gift and not its price

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who asked a king whether doing justice was not the same as knowing Him teach us that our theology is only as sound as our treatment of the people who cannot repay us.

May He keep us from building anything beautiful on wages we never paid, and may nothing we own be worth what it cost someone else.

May He be to us not a manageable God at hand but the One who fills heaven and earth, and may we stop trying to shrink Him to the size of our preferences.

May He raise up in us a hunger for the word that is fire and hammer, and may we grow suspicious of every comfort that has never been anywhere near His council.

May the Branch reign over us - Yahweh our righteousness - and may we stop trying to be our own, since He has already been made ours.

May He gather what has been scattered, and set His eyes on us for good, and build and plant where He once had to pull down and pluck up.

And when our circumstances look like rejection, may we remember the baskets, and trust that the furnace we are in may be exactly where He is forming a heart that knows Him.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.